Democratic Front (AIUDF) general secretary Aminul Islam claimed that the rules to implement PCMA have not been framed by the state yet. Meanwhile, All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM) chief Asaduddin Owaisi asked who will take care of the girls left in the lurch. "You [the Assam government] have already booked 4,000 cases and are in the process of booking another 4,000. Why are they not opening new schools?" he said.

However, refuting such criticism, Sarma has said that the government's action has been unbiased. In fact, in the district where the maximum arrests have been made—Biswanath—over 80 per cent of the population is Hindu. Barpeta, a Muslim-dominated district, has seen the second-highest number of arrests, followed by Dhubri, where nearly 80 per cent of the population is Muslim.



ANI

HOLDING FAST
Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma

THOUGH THE CASES FILED ARE BASED ON PAST OFFENCES, THE GOVERNMENT IS NOW FOCUSING ON PREVENTIVE MEASURES

The cabinet decision was ostensibly triggered by the state's poor performance on certain health indices, as revealed by the National Family Health Survey-5 (NFHS-5) and the Sample Registration System (SRS) Statistical Report of 2020. The NFHS-5, carried out between 2019 and 2020, showed that 31.8 per cent of women aged between 20 and 24 years in Assam got married before the legal age of 18, higher than the national figure of 23.3 per cent. In addition, 11.7 per cent of married women between 15 and 19 years were already mothers or pregnant during the period of the survey, compared to the national average of 6.8 per cent. This has manifested in Assam's abysmal maternal mortality ratio (MMR) and infant mortality rate (IMR). As per the SRS report, Assam's MMR stands at 195 deaths per 100,000 live births—the highest in the country, against a national average of 97. The state's IMR is 36 deaths per 1,000 live births as against the national average of 28.

Even though CM Sarma has been one of the longest-serving health ministers—from 2006 to 2014 in the Congress regime and from 2016 to 2021 under the BJP rule—bringing down IMR and MMR in Assam has been a challenge. "No amount of health infrastructure can help unless people don't change their mindset," he says.

There is another reason why the Sarma government wants to curb child marriages. The NFHS-5 revealed that Assam's total fertility rate (TFR)—the average number of children born per woman—is 1.9, only slightly less than the national average of 2. But the TFR among Muslim women is 2.4, one of the highest in the country. Though it has reduced considerably from a high of 3.6 in 2005-06, there still are local concerns about a possible change in the state's population structure, compounded by illegal immigration from Bangladesh. Between 1971 and 1991, Muslims in Assam grew at 77.42 per cent while Hindus grew at 41.89 per cent. The corresponding figures for Muslims and Hindus for the same period at the national level were 55.04 per cent and 48.38 per cent, respectively.

Though the cases filed are based on past offences, the state has turned its focus on preventive measures. Under these, the secretary of each village panchayat will be appointed as a 'Child Marriage Prohibition Officer', per the Prohibition of Child Marriage Act. The officers are tasked with lodging a police complaint for every child marriage that takes place in a village.

Child rights activists have expressed appreciation for the government's steps. While Priyank Kanungo, chairman of the National Commission for Protection of Child Rights, believes that other states must take similar steps, Miguel Das, a child rights activist, says, "The chief minister's decision has support from almost all organisations working on child protection in Assam. Even in one case, the public resistance to breaking off a child marriage is considerable. In more than 2,000 cases, one can only imagine the magnitude of resistance."

According to the United Nations, India is home to the largest number of child brides in the world: nearly 223 million. In this light, the Assam government's action is perhaps a step in the right direction, but its social and political fallout will have to be managed prudently. ■